The Obama administration's response to these Chinese moves was muddled and hesitant. It initially downplayed the island-building campaign, then condemned it, belatedly demanding that Beijing cease its actions, in response to which Chinese officials darkly warned of war should the United States not stop its pressure campaign. Washington also failed to take advantage of international law in its response to Beijing, even after The Hague's Permanent Court of Arbitration ruled in July 2016 against Chinese claims in a case brought by the Philippines.[10] Declaring that Beijing could not assert ownership over low-elevation landforms, even if they had been built up, and that it had no standing for its historical claims in the South China Sea, The Hague's court should have been a deterrent to China's course. Beijing, however, simply ignored the court's ruling, and the Obama administration did nothing to rally regional pressure on China.

Most noticeably, Obama hesitated to conduct military operations in the contested area, which would have sent clear signals to Beijing that the United States would not meekly surrender the area to China. It took the administration months to decide on freedom of navigation operations (FONOPS) that would come within twelve nautical miles of China's new islands, the territorial limit for legitimate possessions. Only four FONOPS were conducted during Obama's last two years in office, and the US Navy muddied the waters by claiming that it was conducting "innocent passage," which is a different category of transit under international law.[11] Chinese ships and aircraft did not actively interfere with American forces during these operations but instead shadowed them, issuing repeated warnings to leave the area. The end result of Obama's approach was to make the United States appear irresolute and confused about how to blunt China's advances. It further raised doubts in the minds of Asian allies, especially the Philippines, about whether Washington would live up to its treaty commitments.

Donald Trump became president having taken perhaps the hardest line of any presidential candidate toward China. Rejecting prior presidential approaches, Trump explicitly linked trade and security issues,